

Curious Customs of the World

Fifteen peculiar rituals, and the logic hiding inside each one

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Every culture keeps a handful of habits that look baffling from the outside and perfectly logical from the inside. Some began as jokes, some as prayers, some as insurance against a bad harvest. What they share is a genius for turning abstract ideas — courage, grief, gratitude, the passing of a year — into something you can see, hear, taste, or, in a few cases, be hit by. Here are fifteen of the strangest customs on Earth, and the reasoning hidden inside each one.

I. Fire, Food and Flying Vegetables

1. La Tomatina · Buñol, Spain

On the last Wednesday of August, a Valencian town of 9,000 people is overrun by some 20,000 ticketed participants for the largest food fight on the planet. It started by accident in 1945, when a scuffle at a parade escalated into a tomato brawl; the town liked it so much that it came back the next year. Today seven trucks tip 120–150 tonnes of overripe, deliberately inedible tomatoes into the Plaza del Pueblo, and water cannons open and close a battle that lasts exactly one hour. The fruit's acidity scours the streets so thoroughly that Buñol is often cleaner afterwards than it was the day before.

2. The Cheese Rolling · Cooper's Hill, England

Each spring bank holiday, a 3.5 kg wheel of Double Gloucester cheese is rolled down a hill with roughly a 1-in-3 gradient, and dozens of contestants hurl themselves after it. The slope is about 180 metres long and the cheese can hit 70 mph, which means it always wins the race. Volunteers chase it head over heels, somersaulting down the grass; St John Ambulance crews wait at the bottom for the inevitable sprains and bruises. Locals insist the reward is worth the risk: the winner keeps the cheese.

3. The Rocket War · Vrontados, Chios, Greece

On the night before Orthodox Easter, two hilltop parishes in this Aegean village revive a tradition that goes back to the Ottoman era. Thousands of homemade rockets — packed with gunpowder and lit from wooden frames — are fired at each other's bell towers across a ravine, filling the sky with smoke and shrieking light. Church windows are boarded up, worshippers attend in the line of fire, and scoring is so bitterly disputed that the two congregations simply agree to call it a draw and settle the matter the following year.

4. The Battle of the Oranges · Ivrea, Italy

Every February, this Piedmontese town re-enacts a medieval uprising against a tyrannical lord by pelting his 'guards' with oranges. Teams on foot represent the rebellious commoners, while costumed riders on carts play the tyrant's army; hundreds of thousands of kilograms of surplus oranges fly through the streets for three days. Bystanders who want no part of it wear a red cap — the *doppio berretto* — which clearly signals: do not throw at me.

5. The Mud Festival · Boryeong, South Korea

In 1998 the town of Boryeong needed a way to sell its mineral-rich mud cosmetics. Two decades later, its July mud festival draws tens of thousands of visitors who coat themselves head to toe in the stuff on Daecheon Beach. There are mud slides, mud baths, a mud prison, mud massages and a soapy wrestling pit, all washed off at the end of the day in the Yellow Sea. The mud is trucked in from local flats said to be rich in minerals and germanium.

II. Rites of Passage

6. Land Diving · Pentecost Island, Vanuatu

Long before commercial bungee jumping existed, men and boys on this Melanesian island were leaping from towers up to 30 metres tall with nothing but forest vines tied to their ankles. The vines are measured against each diver's own height so that the best land with their hair, or their shoulders, brushing the ground. Performed at the yam harvest, the naghoh is a prayer for a fertile crop and a public test of nerve; legend says it began with a woman who escaped her husband by jumping from a tree, after which the men took up the leap to prove they could do it too.

7. The Bullet-Ant Gloves · Brazilian Amazon

Young men of the Satéré-Mawé people prove they are ready for adulthood by wearing gloves woven from leaves and filled with live bullet ants — the insect whose sting tops the Schmidt pain index and has been described as walking over flaming charcoal with a rusty nail in your heel. The ants are knocked out with a herbal brew before the gloves are woven and wake up as they are worn. Initiates keep them on for five to ten minutes, dancing to distract themselves from the pain, and repeat the ordeal over many months.

8. The Gerewol Beauty Contest · Niger

When the rains end, Wodaabe herders gather for the Cure Salée, and young men compete in a courtship contest that reverses the usual festival roles. They paint their faces with yellow and red ochre, braid their hair, tie on ostrich feathers and strings of beads, then dance the yaake for hours — rolling their eyes and grinning to show off long white teeth, which are considered the height of beauty. Women judge the contest and may choose a new partner by the end of the night.

9. Skulls at Home · La Paz, Bolivia

Every November, families across the Bolivian highlands bring human skulls to the cemetery for a day of celebration. Kept at home through the year, these ñatitas — 'little flat-nosed ones' — are dressed with flowers, sunglasses, hats, coca leaves and sometimes banknotes, and thanked for favours granted. Priests bless them at Mass before the skulls go back to their household shrines, fed and feted, for another year of guarding the family.

III. When the Rules Are Suspended

10. Takanakuy · Chumbivilcas, Peru

In the Peruvian Andes, Christmas Day is settling day. Neighbours who have quarrelled during the year meet in a public arena and fight it out under the eye of a referee, wearing embroidered jackets and carved leather masks that hide their faces and their fear. Punches are exchanged until one fighter yields or the judge stops it, and every bout ends in an embrace. Afterwards the whole community eats, drinks and watches the sun come up, entering the new year without grudges.

11. Nyepi, the Day of Silence · Bali, Indonesia

For twenty-four hours each March, Bali switches itself off. On Nyepi, the Balinese Hindu new year, nobody lights a fire, works, travels or makes a sound; the streets stand empty, hotels draw their curtains, and the island's international airport closes, forcing airlines to reroute around it. The stillness is a decoy: by making the island look abandoned, Balinese families believe they can fool the demons that roam the night. The evening before, huge papier-mâché ogoh-ogoh effigies of those demons are paraded through the villages and burned.

12. The Naked Man Festival · Okayama, Japan

Every February, around nine thousand men wearing only white fundoshi loincloths crowd into Saidaiji Kannon-in temple for hadaka matsuri, one of the coldest and most chaotic rites in Japan. Purification water is thrown over the throng after dark; then the priest flings a hundred sacred wooden sticks into the crowd, and the mass of bodies surges as men fight for them. Touching a stick is said to bring a year of good fortune. The most sought-after figure is the shin-otoko, a chosen 'naked man' hidden somewhere in the crowd — to touch him is believed to be especially lucky.

13. Thaipusam · Malaysia, Singapore, India

Tamil devotees honour the god Murugan by carrying kavadi, decorated arches of wood and steel, along pilgrim routes and up hundreds of temple steps. Some pierce their skin, cheeks and tongues with skewers and small spears in fulfilment of a vow — a spectacle that shocks first-time visitors. The piercings are the end point of weeks of fasting, vegetarianism, celibacy and prayer, and many participants describe entering a trance in which they feel no pain at all. Most are giving thanks for a prayer answered.

14. Baby Jumping · Castrillo de Murcia, Spain

Once a year at Corpus Christi, men dressed as the Colacho — the devil — take a running leap over rows of babies laid out on mattresses in the street. The infants, all born within the previous twelve months, are said to be cleansed of original sin and shielded from illness for the year ahead. The tradition has run since at least 1620, and despite the screaming tabloid headlines, its safety record remains famously unblemished.

15. The Midwinter Feast · Iceland

At the darkest point of the Icelandic winter, families sit down to the food their great-grandparents survived on: hákarl, Greenland shark buried and hung for months to leach out its toxins; svid, a singed sheep's head; blood pudding; and ram testicles, all washed down with Brennivín, the caraway schnapps nicknamed 'Black Death'. Honouring the old Norse month of Thorri, the Thorrablót is equal parts heritage, dare and test of nerve — and it is always better with strangers at the table.

Why We Keep Doing It.

Behind almost every strange custom is an ordinary need: to bind a community together, to mark a season or a threshold, to turn fear of the unknown into a story that people can act out side by side. The details look wild from a distance — rockets, ochre, ants, oranges — but the grammar repeats everywhere: a rule, a costume, a crowd, a reason to gather. Nor are these traditions frozen in amber. Up Helly Aa, the Shetland fire festival that has lit up the last Tuesday of January since the 1880s and burns a hand-built Viking longship each year, opened its Jarl Squad to women for the first time in 2024. So the next time a custom looks inexplicable, remember that it almost certainly makes perfect sense from the inside.

BY THE NUMBERS

120–150 tonnes of overripe tomatoes thrown during one hour of La Tomatina

1,000+ torches carried through Lerwick at Shetland's Up Helly Aa

4.0+ the bullet ant's score on Schmidt's insect-sting pain index, the top of the scale

24 hours for which Bali's international airport closes for Nyepi

Compiled September 2026 from festival organisers, national tourism boards and press reports. Dates, figures and attendance numbers vary from year to year and are given as approximations.